

100 Days of Linux - Day 081

Title: Introduction to Environment Variables - env & printenv

Today's Goal

Learn what environment variables are and how to view them using the **env** and **printenv** commands.

Why This Matters

Environment variables store important system information used by applications, programming languages, shells and development tools.

Commands of the Day

env - Display all environment variables.

printenv - Display all variables or a specific variable.

Syntax:

env

printenv

printenv HOME

Examples:

env

printenv PATH

printenv USER

Beginner Lesson

An environment variable is a named value stored by the operating system. Programs use these values to find folders, user information and configuration settings. The **env** command lists all variables, while **printenv** can show all variables or one specific variable.

Practice Questions

1. Display all environment variables using **env**.
2. Display all environment variables using **printenv**.
3. Display only the **HOME** variable.
4. Display the **PATH** variable.
5. Display the **USER** variable.

Hints

Use **env** to list everything. Use **printenv** followed by a variable name to display one variable.

Mini Challenge

Create a Markdown file named `environment_notes.md` and write the values of **HOME**, **PATH** and **USER** from your system.

Common Mistakes

Typing variable names in lowercase, confusing **env** with **printenv**, or expecting **env** to display only one variable.

Did You Know?

Many development tools automatically read environment variables such as **PATH** to locate executables.

Pro Tip

Learn the **PATH**, **HOME** and **USER** variables first because you will use them throughout your Linux journey.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: **env**

Q2: **printenv**

Q3: **printenv HOME**

Q4: **printenv PATH**

Q5: **printenv USER**

Homework

List five environment variables from your system and write a one-line description of what each represents.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn how to create and use your own shell variables.